beckoned. He quoted the following verses by a tenth-century Ismaili writer that some Shias at court were using in praise of Akbar, to illustrate his point.

> In 989 according to the decree of fate,
> The stars from all sides shall meet together.
> In the year of Leo the month of Leo, the day of Leo
> The Lion of God will stand forth from behind the veil.

In the same month, a great feast was held by Abdur Rahim to celebrate his new position as ataliq of Salim. Abdur Rahim invited the emperor to be present at the banquet and the young nobleman outdid himself in the gorgeous arrangements he organized. The path from the fort of the walled city to Abdur Rahim's haveli was strewn with flowers made of gold and silver. Outside the haveli itself, rubies were scattered along the lane. The entrance to his residence was lined with cloths of satin and velvet while, inside the grounds, Abdur Rahim had a dais made at the cost of 1,25,000 rupees. Once the Padshah was seated, Abdur Rahim offered him jewels, exquisite garments, and refined and advanced weapons of war. The feast prepared would have had the favoured combinations of meat and dried fruit, as well as large quantities of saffron and asafoetida (hing), which were all Persian staples. Asafoetida brought in by the Mughals became very popular with the vegetarian population of Hindustan because, when cooked in oil, it took on a garlicky flavour that made it a good substitute for onions and garlic. It was also a good digestive, useful in combination with indigestible pulses and beans, and quickly became an indispensable part of local cuisine. So pleased was Akbar with this celebration that he offered Abdur Rahim all the insignia of royalty normally reserved for princes of the blood. Mirza Khan was now a nobleman to be reckoned with.

That the exuberance and fevered anticipation around the coming of the new Islamic millennium led to a great deal of mystical experimentation in the sixteenth century is well known. The belief that this was when a mujaddid, or renewer, would appear to cleanse Islam of corruption, and renew its essence had been building in successive waves of fervour and fury as different sects were convinced that they were the ones to offer the final truth. For Akbar, this appeared to be a cosmically perfect time in which to finally perfect and declare the many ideas he had been experimenting with. From the time Akbar had witnessed the fallibility of the orthodox ulema in